

OH, MUXIMA! THE FORMATION OF URBAN POPULAR MUSIC OF ANGOLA AND THE GROUP "N'GOLA RITMOS" (1940-1950)

Resumo: O presente artigo trata de uma importante fase da música popular urbana de Angola, que se dá a partir dos anos 1940. Buscamos, contudo, dissertar sobre a história de um grupo musical específico, o “N’gola Ritmos”. Nossa opção pelo tema se deve por compreendermos a importância do conjunto e a sua posição de liderança durante os anos cinquenta do século XX, sobretudo, na cidade de Luanda. Palavras-chave: Angola. História. Música. “N’gola Ritmos”.

Abstract: This article will deal with a major phase of urban popular music of Angola, which takes place from the 1940s will seek, however, speak about the history of a particular musical group, "N'gola Rhythms". Our choice of theme is due to understand the importance of the whole and its leading position during the fifties of the twentieth century, particularly in the city of Luanda. Keywords: Angola. History. Music. "N'gola Rhythms".

Resumen: El presente artículo trata de una importante fase de la música popular urbana de Angola, que se da a partir de los años 1940. Buscamos, pero, dissertar sobre la historia de um grupo musical específico, lo “N’gola Ritmos”. Nuestra opción por el tema se debe por comprender la importancia del conjunto y su posición de liderazgo durante los años cincuneta del siglo XX, sobre todo, en la ciudad de Luanda. Palavras clave: Angola. Historia. Música. “N’gola Ritmos”.

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In his article *Estórias da música em Angola*, the Angolan researcher and musician Mário Rui Silva states:

"Luandan musical culture is the fruit of various encounters. Diverse population groups arrived in Luanda from various regions of Angola [...]. These groups brought with them their own cultural universe and as time advanced they adapted to the new realities" (SILVA, 1996, p. 33).

Jomo Fortunato (2009), an important Angolan music critic and researcher, adds that Angolan popular music, which is updated in the urban space, was 'contaminated' and absorbed, throughout its formation process, the execution techniques of Western musical instruments. According to him, it is in this framework, characterized by a complex intersection of influences, that Angolan popular music took shape and acquired the structure we know today.

In general, there is a music that configures itself in the rural space, characterized by diverse cultural practices and customs, which ended up influencing the music of the urban space. An important characteristic pointed out by Fortunato reveals that: while urban popular music always has an individualized composer and is more prone to influences, traditional music, from the rural space, is essentially distinguished by anonymity in composition; that is, the notion of authorship is annulled by time, and musical compositions are accepted as collective productions within the communities. The ethnomusicologist Kazadi Wa Mukuna (1985, p. 77-78), moreover, defined African music as an 'event-music', precisely because it is of a collective nature. In this same direction, the Nigerian writer Wole Soyinka (2010, p. 633-637) explains to us that the socially integrating role of music remained the most characteristic aspect of the cultural life of the African continent. We must not forget that African music inscribes itself in the spaces of the community, because besides being a collective creation, it enables and establishes forms of sociability. This is, in fact, a dear principle to the majority of African communities.

Musical learning is thus inscribed in memory and is transmitted orally, from generation to generation. According to Tania Macêdo, orality is the way of accumulating and transmitting knowledge about the history of each group. Besides this, daily teachings are carried out through orality, with memories and the role of elders having fundamental importance. For the author: "It is a complex operation that mobilizes values and, above all, the belief in the power of the word" (2008, p. 45). From this perspective, different researchers have found that multiple types of knowledge in African societies are grasped through the spoken word. This is the case, for example, of Jan Vansina (2010, p. 139-140) and Hampaté Bâ (2010, p. 167-169), who argue that African civilizations are civilizations of the spoken word, as they are fundamentally based on dialogue between individuals and on communication between communities or ethnic groups. They (and other researchers) note that oral narratives, myths, proverbs, poems, music, and scientific knowledge have persisted on the foundations of orality.

Regarding African singing, the aforementioned researcher, Kazadi Wa Mukuna (1985, p. 78) explains to us that there are some songs that are taken on only by the soloist; others are sung in unison by the group, and there are also those divided between the soloist and the choir, where the soloist sings the melody and the group completes it. Called responsorial singing (or antiphonal execution), this type of singing is a kind of 'conversation' between the soloist and the choir. We will see, later, that this was a typical way of singing for the members of the group "N'gola Ritmos".

With the passage of time, the anonymous composers of that phase described by Jomo Fortunato started to add parts of their authorship to the compositions. Mário Rui Silva (1996, p. 34) emphasizes that in the mid-1930s, names such as Alfredo Lopes, António Palma, Amílcar and Eurico Neves, Álvaro Caldas, Adão Correia, Fansony, Domingos Benedito de Palma, Filipe Amado, Flávio Galiano, Guilherme de Assis, Horácio Van-Dúnem, José Vieira Dias, José Oliveira de Fontes Pereira, Luís Gomes Sambo, Mestre Geraldo, Manuel dos Passos, Nga Firmino, Óscar Ribas, Teófilo José da Costa, Voto Neves, Viroscas, and many others already stood out.

The 'turmas', fundamental in that context, were the 'embryo' of the majority of Angolan musical groups that came to stand out in the cities. It was an ensemble formed by young people who performed typical songs and dances, using drums, a snare or stool, a reco-reco, and shakers. Besides the semba, the 'turmas' performed the merengue and the Brazilian samba with local lyrics. Massemba, a popular umbigada dance performed by couples of dancers, is the plural of semba, a name that came to designate the most representative musical genre of the Luanda region.

Ruy Duarte de Carvalho (1993, p. 19-24) points out that these small formations emancipated themselves, alternately, from the large carnival groups. Carnival in Luanda, by the way, has been, since the 19th century, the popular festival par excellence. According to him, little is known, in fact, about the origin of the Luandan Carnival. However, what seems certain to us is the participation of the less favored classes in the party. Óscar Ribas, to whom we owe the record of many carnival practices in the Luanda region, points out the existence of some groups and identifies certain traits and behaviors that still persist in the carnival manifestations of Luanda, such as the performance of six types of dance: semba, kabetula, kazukuta, maringa, dizanda, and cidrália (RIBAS apud BIRMINGHAM, 1991, p. 428).

Ruy Duarte de Carvalho (1993, p. 23) describes to us some important moments of the festival: the exhibitions in the neighborhoods follow a schedule of itineraries that aims to present the group to its supporters who live, above all, in the neighborhood to which the group belongs. During the exhibitions, the group's sympathizers offer money, deposited between the lips of the 'queen', while she dances. After receiving the money, the 'queen' hands it to a male or female 'treasurer', also dancers of the group, to be kept in the briefcase of the 'nurse', a mandatory character in the cast of the Luanda Carnival. During the presentations through the neighborhoods, the groups can cross paths with other groups and it is exactly at this moment that the type of relationship existing between them becomes evident, with great prominence, since each group has its rivals and its allies. This fact is of great importance in the internal life of each group and even in the very dynamics of the Luandan Carnival, especially in the domain of musical creations, where the existence and vitality of the rival group is an indispensable element.

During the 1940s, in the carnival groups of the Luanda musseques, the use of percussions and the dikanza gains strength, alongside the cornet, the whistle, and the shakers. Evidently, the groups incorporated ideas and instruments that circulated in these spaces, while at the same time they became dynamic elements of Luandan popular music.

The agglomeration of people in the restricted areas of the musseques was permitted by police authorities to hold parties on weekends and not just at carnival, transforming these spaces into a fruitful environment for the circulation of ideas, creation, and dissemination of songs. According to Jomo Fortunato: "[...] in the past, Angolan music was more connected to its origins. With the arrival of the Portuguese, the natives were pushed to the periphery, creating the urban space of the musseques which would become very important for the development of popular music. The musseques are not the city, it is more countryside. They spoke a very correct Kimbundu and absorbed the so-called traditional songbook".

We know that with the intensification of Portuguese immigration and the migration of Angolans from other parts of the province to Luanda, the musseques became even more precarious and overpopulated. As Juliana Bosslet (2014, p. 29) points out, the high prices of overseas products on the international market added to the considerable increase of the metropolitan population in Angola, especially in Luanda, generated the beginning of an urbanization process of the capital and industrialization in the colony. Such transformations ended up attracting Angolans from other areas of the province who, yearning for better living conditions and opportunities in the nascent industry, migrated to the capital. This process generated serious housing problems, especially in the musseques.

For the geographer Ilídio do Amaral (1983, p. 312-318), the musseques are the result of the accelerated growth of economic activities, mostly of an urban nature, added to the uncontrolled population increase, particularly by means of intensive immigration. This process 'swells' the population of the musseques with a mass of unemployed people, people with low professional qualifications, and some small merchants. The scholar further notes that, throughout Luanda's history, the musseques were environments with precarious living conditions for their inhabitants, where the occurrence of fires and epidemics was recurrent. Heavy rains also constituted a major problem for musseque residents. The writer José Luandino Vieira in the work *Luuanda* reports one of these moments and the consequence of the rains for the residents of the musseques: "And when the great thunder came out over the musseque, shaking the weak wattle and daub walls and detaching wood, cardboard, everyone closed their eyes frightened by the blue brightness of the lightning that was born in the sky [...] the musseque, at that hour, seemed like a sanzala in the middle of the lagoon, the streets of rain, the huts invaded by that red and dirty water, running towards the tar that leads to the Baixa or staying, stubborn, in puddles breeding mosquitoes and the noises of frogs" (VIEIRA, 1972, p. 14-15).

Besides literature, we also find some songs by Angolan composers that signal the new and difficult living conditions faced by the population of the musseques. This is the case of the song "Chofer de Praça", composed by Xabanu and interpreted by Luís Visconde. The lyrics inform us:

I hailed a taxi
Anxious to see my love
Taxi driver then complained
When I told him that my darling lived in the suburbs:
"Rainy weather in the suburbs, I won't go
Because I'm a taxi driver and not a boatman".
Then I begged: "Please Mr. driver take me please
She is not to blame for living in the suburbs
While the rain is nature's work".
Then driver dominated by me
Pulled on the rubber, crossing the lagoon
When I looked at my watch
And asking him to glue the accelerator to the mat.
Then sullen driver replied:
"If you want to see your love, cross the lagoon on foot.
I'm not going to break my ride just because you want to show off".

The lyrics of Xabanu's song make us reflect on racial discrimination in Luanda which was established, also, through the very urbanization of the city. Jacques Arlindo dos Santos (1999, p. 286) in his memoir about the Bairro Operário comments that not all taxi drivers had, at that time, enough courage to drive through the interior of suburban neighborhoods, like the Bairro Operário, and under the most diverse pretexts they refused to transport natives, especially when the ride ended in the musseque. As Marcelo Bittencourt argues, the Angolan colonial daily life, during the 1950s, allowed the coexistence of blacks, mestizos, and whites in certain spaces that went beyond work, however, as the author explains, "[...] this does not mean an easing of racism, quite the contrary, racial categories emerge strengthened as a mechanism of social demarcation" (BITTENCOURT, 2010, p. 09).

However, we consider it important to note that the musseques became transition spaces between the rural universe and the city, "transforming themselves into a textual laboratory of the songs that were absorbed by the expectations of the urban cultural environment" (FORTUNATO, 2009, s/p). We were able to verify that the themes of the songs circulating in these spaces were varied and also spoke about the son lost at sea, sexual harassment between the boss and the domestic maid, marital conflicts, amorous infidelity, the carnival, nostalgia for childhood, and the composer's frustration at not having attended school.

However, we would like to highlight that Luanda's musseques were privileged spaces for the dissemination of the music of the group "N'gola Ritmos". Its founder, Liceu Vieira Dias, explains that the ensemble was created in the late 1940s at Manuel dos Passos's house, at the moment when a group of youths, among them, Liceu, Domingos Van-Dúnem, Francisco Machado, and Nino Mário Araújo (Nino Ndongo) met on Saturday and Sunday afternoons to play and sing. In the quote below, Liceu Vieira Dias gives us details about the group's creation: "N'gola Ritmos was created exactly because there was a need to continue doing the work of disseminating our music [...], seeking to recover folkloric themes and popular themes that were being lost [...]. So we sang some original things and we got together and N'gola Ritmos made its public appearance with songs that were from the popular repertoire".

As Jomo Fortunato (2009, s/p) well explains to us, the members of "N'gola Ritmos" can be considered pioneers of the aesthetic modernity of Angolan music, in the sense of innovative proposals and stylization of the popular songbook. The group's musicians inserted new chords and the bass guitar (six strings), the drum, and the dikanza led the rhythmic marking, with the voice intervening in counterpoint. As we have already informed, this is the so-called responsorial singing, a characteristic way of singing for various peoples of Africa. The 'puxador' (puller), singer, or master is designated as the one responsible for the initial chant and the choir can be accompanied by musical instruments. The song "Birin Birin", interpreted by the group, is a typical example of this way of singing. Below, we transcribe the lyrics of the song, composed in Kimbundu:

Wé lé lé lé lé lé lé

Kisangela ngwetwé ni mazundwé

Wé lé lé lé lé lé lé

Kisangela ngwetwé ni mazundwé.

Oso ua dimuka

Kudya ngo wé lumoxi

Oso ua dimuka

Kudya ngo wé lumoxi.

Birin Birin

Ngongo yamyé

Birin Birin

Ngongo yamyé

Wa tambula a wanga

Wibula ze

Birin Birin

Ngongo yamyé.

Liceu Vieira Dias defined the group's aesthetic lines, introducing melody, lyrics, and adapting the acoustic guitar to the Angolan rhythm, by incorporating the famous 'descompassada beat' (off-beat) which, incidentally, characterizes it so much. In this phase, themes collected from popular tradition multiply, such as the song "Henda Ya Xala", one of the first compositions interpreted by the group:

Ue-le-le-le

Henda ya-xala!

Henda i-xala

Filo paié

Filo manhé

Ue-le-le-le

Zé Kumbela!

Xoke xoke

Kalu-uaia xoké

The group's way of singing is inspired by popular tradition, especially by the *bessanganas*, funeral lamentations sung by women. The song "Mon'ami" ("My Son") is an example of this style. The song, interpreted by Lourdes Van-Dúnem, recounts the suffering of a mother mourning the death of her son:

Talenu ngó!
O Kituxi ki ngabange?
Talunu ngó!
Maka mami ma jingongo!
Ngexile Kyá
ni an'ami Kiyadi
Nzambi K'andalê
Ngaxala ni umoxi
Ngibanga kyebyê?!
Ngaxala ngoê
ni umoxi.
Ngibanga kyebi?
O kituxi Ki ngabangyê?!
Mona wambote wajimbirila
Ngidila ngoê!
Ngibanza ngoê!
Ay, mon'ami!

As Fortunato (2010, s/p) argues, the precepts of colonial society reserved for women a limited artistic mobility and a social role confined to very rigid behavioral rules. In this context, we highlight the trajectory of the singer Maria de Lourdes Pereira dos Santos Van-Dúnem, better known as Lourdes Van-Dúnem. The artist was born in the Coqueiros neighborhood, in Luanda, on April 29, 1935. It was with the composition and recording of the theme "Mon'ami" that she began to be recognized by the general public. Her first appearance with "N'gola Ritmos" was in 1950 during a variety show organized by the Experimental Theater Group, "GEXTO".

In 1957, Lourdes Van-Dúnem joined and founded the "Feminine Trio", formed by Belita Palma (drums), Conceição Legot (guitar) and Lourdes Van-Dúnem (dikanza). From this phase, we highlight the songs "A máscara da face" and "Diá Ngo", by the Feminine Trio. In 1957 the singer did some work as a radio announcer, presenting the programs "Kapapumuka" and "Kussungula", at the then Official Broadcaster of Angola.

Upon watching the video of Lourdes Van Dúnem's presentation with "N'gola Ritmos" on the stages of Portuguese TV, some details caught our attention, mainly those related to the clothing of the singer and the musicians. First, we cannot neglect the fact that fashion has the capacity to reveal political postures and affirm individuality. We understand that this data is quite relevant considering that the group "N'gola Ritmos" always sought to value the traditional culture of Angola, recovering and prioritizing in its repertoire themes of popular origin and using typical instruments of the country during its performances. On the other hand, the presentation of Lourdes (and other members of the ensemble), in Portugal, occurred at a time when Lusotropicalism was gaining strength in the metropolis. In this sense, we cannot fail to comment, even if in general terms, that there was an attempt by the Portuguese government to make the group's presentation 'exotic'. After all, appealing to the "traditional" and picturesque was certainly a means of garnering acceptance before the Portuguese public and confirming the idea of respect for local characteristics and cultures.

Another female voice that stood out in "N'gola Ritmos" was that of Belita Palma, artistic name of Isabel Salomé Benedito de Palma Teixeira. Daughter of Domingos Benedito Palma - a musician linked to a philharmonic band - and Rosa da Silva Guimarães Palma, Belita was born on October 15, 1932, in Luanda. The singer intensely attended the gatherings organized in the "Viúva Leal" neighborhood, at the home of her maternal grandmother, where Liceu Vieira Dias, Nino Ndongo, and Gabriel Leitão met on Saturday afternoons. At the end of the 1960s, the singer began her solo career. In this phase, accompanied by the ensemble "Os Kiezos", she recorded two singles, containing the themes "Kangrima", "Astronauta", "Sá da Bandeira", and "Apollo 11", the last three being compositions authored by her sister, Rosita Palma. Belita Palma, incidentally, revealed herself, fundamentally, as an interpreter of her sister Rosita's songs. In the period just after independence, she included in her repertoire the themes "Caminho do Mato" (poem by Agostinho Neto, set to music by Tonito), "04 de fevereiro" (Rosita Palma), and "11 de novembro" (Rosita Palma) (FORTUNATO, 2010, s/p; WEZA, 2007, p. 81-82).

Regarding the rhythmic issue of "N'gola Ritmos", it is essential that we emphasize the presence of the dikanza, a typical instrument from Angola. Much of the repertoire of "N'gola Ritmos" includes the use of the instrument, mainly under the performance of Fontinhas, artistic name of Euclides Fontes Pereira. Fontinhas was born in Luanda on November 2, 1925, and grew up in a family of musicians and artists. His father, José de Fontes Pereira, also known as "Abel Mwené ó Dikota", was a concertina player and founder of the "Elite União Clube", a massamba group from the first half of the 20th century. Fontinhas' sister, "Mama Lala", was the first Carnival queen of the "Cidrália" group; his paternal uncles, Luís de Fontes Pereira and António de Fontes Pereira composed several songs, among them "Ó massangu ngi madiami" and "Diá Ngó". Another very important figure to remember is his brother, José Oliveira de Fontes Pereira, also called "Malé Malamba". He was a composer, dancer, choreographer, and the founder of the first semba school in Angola in the late 1950s. José de Oliveira Fontes Pereira, like his brother Fontinhas, was a great defender of the use of the dikanza. The defense was made, even, by the use of the term dikanza and not reco-reco. According to José de Oliveira Fontes Pereira, "reco-reco is an onomatopoeia that associates the sound of the dikanza, when rubbed by the 'kixikilu', a rhythmic friction stick. The correct term is dikanza" (PEREIRA apud FORTUNATO, 2014, s/p). The following definition is also his: "The dikanza is an accompanying instrument that joins, rhythmically and harmonically, with the concertina, the guitar, and the drum. [...] there is a constructive model, based on eighteen steps, to obtain a perfect dikanza. A process that goes from cutting the staff, in the desired size, to obtain the height, passing through marking to determine the divisions of the grooves that will constitute the rhythmic sector, until the polishing" (PEREIRA apud FORTUNATO, 2014, s/p).

Fontinhas was the main dikanza player of the group "N'gola Ritmos" and, like his brother, manufactured the instrument. We can state that "Nzaji" ("lightning" in Kimbundu) is the theme where Fontinhas exercises all his skill as a dikanza player and composer. The composition was reelaborated by Fontinhas, according to information collected from his father, a great connoisseur of Luanda tales from the 1920s. We would like to highlight, however, the presence of the responsorial singing, a striking characteristic in the interpretation of the song, whose lyrics we highlight below:

Nzaji, nzaji, nzaji,

Salambinga

Nzaji ngamutulula mwenyê

Salambinga

Nzaji, kya kina k'anyok'ê

Salambinga

Oh! Oh! Oh! Salambinga

Ngenyami ya kuzuata

n'ya kudifuta

Oh mwanya ki utwa

jindolo jingivula

ngibbanga kyebê

ngi mukua ngongo

Mukuxixima kwami ngô

Wa wê mangolê

Nzaji, nzaji, nzaji,

Salambinga.

Another emblematic composition of "N'gola Ritmos", recovered from popular tradition, is "Muxima". The word 'muxima', in Kimbundu, means 'heart'. The composition tells us of the plea of someone who, being accused of witchcraft, asks to be taken to the sanctuary of "Muxima" to prove they are innocent. Once again, we observe the presence of responsorial singing. The lyrics are as follows:

Muxima wo wo

Muxima wo wo Muxima

Eye wangamba wanga wami

Kangi beke bwa Santana.

Eye wangamba wanga wami

Kangi beke bwa Santana.

Kwata odilaji Mujibé

Laji ni laji kasokawa.

Kwata odilaji Mujibé

Laji ni lagi kazókawa.

Muxima wo wo

Muxima wo wo Muxima.

Amadeu Amorim, ex-member of the ensemble, explains that the song "Muxima" arrived in the city of Léopoldville on the radio programs of the MPLA (Popular Movement for the Liberation of Angola) and for this reason it became very associated with Angolan nationalism, even gaining international repercussions.

Here, we believe it is important to open a parenthesis to inform the reader about the political transformations that occurred in Angola in the late 1950s, when new clandestine organizations began to emerge, but with a much larger territorial reach, as well as the participation of militants on a scale unknown until then. That would be the case of the MPLA, the Popular Movement for the Liberation of Angola. Marcelo Bittencourt (2002, p. 51) explains that the MPLA is the result of the anti-colonial agitation initiated in the late 1940s, but which extended throughout the 1950s. According to the scholar, its formation stems from two nationalist currents consisting of those who were in the colony, known as "those from the interior", and those who were in the metropolis, in other European countries, and, more rarely, in African countries. All of these would become known as "those from the exterior". Norrie Macqueen (1998, p. 39) clarifies that the movement—initially led by Viriato da Cruz and Mário de Andrade—received, from its founding, the support of urbanized Africans and mestizos who were concentrated mainly in the Luanda region. In Macqueen's words, "the MPLA symbolized an alliance between the intelligentsia and the proletariat, social categories more usually associated with Europe than with sub-Saharan Africa in the mid-1950s" (MACQUEEN, 1998, p. 39).

In Angola, other groups stood out in the anti-colonial movement, such as the Bakongo, in the northern region of the colony. From the moment the Portuguese began to advance into the interior, relationships had been established with the traditional Congo monarchy, which even came to occupy a prominent position in the colonial regime. With the death of the Bakongo king, D. Pedro VII, in 1955, a struggle began over the succession of his position, resulting in the formation of the Union of Populations of Northern Angola (UPNA), with Holden Roberto being the main figure of this movement. In 1958, the "N" in UPNA was dropped, and it came to be called the Union of Populations of Angola (UPA). Such a strategic name change aimed to reach a multiethnic national identity which, in truth, the movement never achieved. In 1962, the UPA changed its name again, becoming the National Liberation Front of Angola (FNLA) (MACQUEEN, 1998, p. 39-40).

Regarding the social composition of the FNLA, we can affirm that its founders were mostly peasants and Protestants, members of traditional families from the northern region of Angola. Holden Roberto's leadership, based on ethnic and family issues, ended up generating criticism from several members belonging to other ethnic groups within the FNLA. Opposing this position, a small group of militants broke with the FNLA and created a new liberation movement in Angola. It was the National Union for the Total Independence of Angola (UNITA), created in 1966 and led by Jonas Savimbi.

With regard to the foreign policy established by the aforementioned liberation movements, it is worth noting, initially, that UNITA drew closer to China, defining itself ideologically as a Maoist movement, with revolutionary and peasant bases. Subsequently, the movement allied itself with South Africa and the USA. In the search for support, the FNLA ended up approaching the Americans, an attitude which was heavily questioned by the MPLA, which understood that the movement intended a neocolonialist outcome for Angola right after independence. Gradually, the MPLA grew closer to Cuba and the then USSR.

In line with what we highlighted above, the MPLA had a radio program in Brazzaville, 'Voice of Combatant Angola'. Marcelo Bittencourt (2002) clarifies that Brazzaville, in particular, would mean an important step for the MPLA, which had already made an attempt to establish radio programs in Léopoldville, but without success. This situation would reverse in Brazzaville: "Inaugurated in December 1940, during the Second World War, Radio Brazzaville would, by June 1943, rely on new transmitters, much more powerful than the previous ones. Radio Brazzaville brought a dynamic and a presence nonexistent until then. Before the radio, guerrilla actions were known through rumors which, in a climate of repression, did not always reach wider segments. The lack of information about the ideas and trajectory of the MPLA was another point to be reversed" (BITTENCOURT, 2002, p. 309).

'Combatant Angola' was broadcast on Wednesdays and Sundays, always at 7:00 PM. Surely, the program was one of the most important instruments for disseminating the MPLA's proposals. Amadeu Amorim, a former member of "N'gola Ritmos", recalls that they "opened" the program with the group's repertoire, especially with the song "Muxima", which we cited earlier. We understand that the choice of this song by the radio and program directors was not random. At that time, "Muxima" was the most famous song by "N'gola Ritmos" and, as we know, the group was a pioneer in the interpretation (and composition) of songs in Kimbundu.

On this topic, we cannot forget that in the mid-1940s and 1950s, traditional African songs were rejected by the colonial system. As Conceição Neto recalls, during the 20th century, Portuguese expanded naturally, accompanying European immigration, but contrary to what is sometimes stated, there was never a law forbidding the speaking of Bantu languages. In any case, by prohibiting their use in schools and since abandoning their practice was one of the preconditions for obtaining the status of "civilized citizen", those languages were increasingly marginalized (NETO, 1997, p. 338). The musicians of this phase, especially the members of "N'gola Ritmos", were able to establish a link between the countryside and the city, composing and interpreting songs of popular origin. Joaquim Pinto de Andrade in an article for the magazine *África Hoje* reports that in the colonial context of the 1940s and 1950s, the emergence of "N'gola Ritmos" meant "a true cultural subversion of linguistic values and of the artistic and aesthetic standards considered as the only valid ones by the ruling class" (ANDRADE, 1989, p. 34), demanding a cultural identity and the right to difference.

In an interview with journalist Sílvia Milonga, Amadeu Amorim emphasized the role played by the group and the reaction of the people when they heard the interpreters singing in the national language: "when we sang in Kimbundu, people turned their faces half ashamed, calling us 'mussequeiros' [...]; whoever spoke it was considered backward, gentile" (AMORIM apud MILONGA, s/d and s/p). Now, according to our evidence, "N'gola Ritmos" was predominantly formed by 'assimilated' individuals, according to the Angolan social classification of that period. On this subject, it is important to remember that at the end of the 1920s, colonial legislation attempted for the first time, explicitly, to define and separate the colony's Creole elite, including the majority of educated mestizos and blacks, who officially became known as 'assimilados' (DIAS, 1984, p. 74).

In 1954, the 'Statute of Portuguese Natives of Guinea, Angola and Mozambique' was published, standardizing the regulation of the 'assimilation charter'. José de Oliveira Cabaço (2007, p. 153; 162-163) highlights that Decree-Law no. 39.666, which publishes the Statute, is an important document to mention, as it already seeks to address 'special situations' for natives who were 'on the path of civilization'. As the author highlights, the Statute unifies the criteria for 'assimilation', defining the requirements that, 'cumulatively', the candidate would have to possess, such as speaking the Portuguese language correctly. However, if, on the one hand, assimilation would give the individual the legal status of 'citizen', "[...] on the social level, he would always remain a subordinated member, never seen by the colonists as 'one of us'" (CABAÇO, 2007, p. 162-163).

In this direction, Albert Memmi points out: "[...] to assimilate, it is not enough to leave one's group, it is necessary to penetrate another: now, he (the colonized) encounters the refusal of the colonizer" (MEMMI, 1989, p. 109). The scholar asserts that racism is an ideology that collectivizes; it is the blacks who bear innate characteristics that make them inferior. In this way, racism makes assimilation a contradiction, because even if accepted by Portuguese legislation, the black person, even if assimilated, would always be the 'other'. In other words, it would be a social exclusion based on race, perhaps this being the main aspect of the contradiction of the colonial order. Based on this perspective, we also cite the Indian scholar Homi Bhabha. For him, the skin is the key signifier of cultural and racial difference, acting publicly in the daily racial drama of colonial societies (BHABHA, 1992, p. 196; 198). Stated differently, skin color becomes a cultural/political sign of inferiority and degeneration. Furthermore, the domination and hegemony exercised in the colonial context in Angola (and other Portuguese colonies) had as their support racial ideologies that legitimized historical and social differences as biological.

It is never too much to remember that in the mid-19th century, in line with the economic and political transformations that marked the implementation of colonialism, the first anthropological approaches to the question of the 'primitive societies' of the territories resulting from European expansion emerged. Charles Darwin's work *The Origin of Species*, published in 1859, would profoundly modify the view of life and man and scientific knowledge in general. It was under the 'sign of evolutionism' that European thought developed and, in this context, the 'evolution of man' would proceed through historical phases, where European civilization would be the superior model of progress and, therefore, the classificatory reference point (CABAÇO, 2007, p. 111-112). Renato da Silveira (1999, p. 93-94) explains that the notion of race, during the second half of the 19th century, became central in the reflection of social scientists, encompassing the concepts of society, culture, and even civilization. The new theorists of the 'superiority of the white race' identified it, then, as the vanguard of the other 'races'.

In Luanda, the notion of race became a strong segregating factor in society, a factor intensified by the increase in colonist immigration in the first decades of the 20th century. According to Jacques Arlindo dos Santos (1999), none of the members of "N'gola Ritmos" is a native of the Bairro Operário, however, all of them, with the exception of Liceu Vieira Dias, lived there. Nino Ndongo, son of Rodrigues Ndongo, a musician from the 1930s, lived in the neighborhood for several years, as did Xodó and Zé Maria. José Cordeiro lived with his parents in the Bairro Operário, and Amadeu Amorim, born in the Ingombotas neighborhood, lived there from ten to twenty years of age. And to understand this spatial concentration of the group members, it is essential to take into account the race factor in colonial society.

Generally, "N'gola Ritmos" performed in the Luanda musseques, at the African National League, and frequently, in the Bairro Operário, according to the image we highlight just below, where we can observe the group, parading through its streets, during the Carnival of 1956.

Unlike the previous image (of the Bairro Operário), in Benguela, in the year 1957, we visualize the participation of the group's singers, Lourdes Van-Dúnem and Belita Palma.

Once again it is Jacques dos Santos (1999, p. 144) who narrates an episode involving the group "N'gola Ritmos", which occurred at the 'Bar América', located in the Bairro Operário. This bar/restaurant had as its primary clientele the white Portuguese who lived in the neighborhood. In heterogeneous spaces, like the Bairro Operário which, in the mid-1950s, had the presence of whites, Creoles, 'new assimilados' and 'indígenas', the existence of racial and also 'spatial' segregation often 'exploded violently'. As the author reports, when "N'gola Ritmos" sang some songs in Kimbundu at that bar, it caused immense discomfort to the Portuguese who were there. Another episode narrated by Santos (1999, p. 225-226) reveals that when performing at the "Nacional Cine Teatro", during the 1950s, the ensemble members were simply harassed by the Portuguese who, upon hearing the songs sung in Kimbundu, reacted with phrases like: "go away, go sing to the sanzala!".

Both Amorim's speech and the events narrated by Arlindo Jacques dos Santos lead us to deduce that in the colonial situation in Africa, domination was imposed by a foreign minority in the name of an ethnic and cultural superiority. By establishing categories such as 'indigenous', 'native', or 'assimilated', the colonizer prescribes identity categories and defines the nature of the relationship between themselves and those in a dominated situation (SERRANO, 2008). Such segregation facilitated the persecution of cultural movements that yearned to value native culture. This repression generated a prejudice against the language and musical rhythms, then seen as signs of an uncivilized culture. In the words of Moema Parente Augel, it would be to "discredit, disregard the autochthonous culture to the detriment of the imposed culture, intoxicating the colonized with the elixir of civilization; it was a recurrent and efficient strategy" (AUGEL, 2007, p. 133).

As Augel aptly warns, the colonizing powers, willing to impose their presence as a reference center, "committed themselves to the constant extermination of original and autochthonous traits" (AUGEL, 2007, p. 273) in an attempt to stifle their traditions, viewed as outdated and primitive. By choosing to sing compositions of Angolan popular origin in the national language, the members of "N'gola Ritmos" deviate from that conduct, affirming the need to value national cultures. Furthermore, they transmitted messages that spoke of the need for change, as in the composition "Messene" ("Master" in Kimbundu), a song that, according to Amadeu Amorim (in given interviews), alerted to the need to know how to read and write.

Messene za tulona ó kuegia kutanga

Tundé ka tuvalele ó kutanga nuca tuakimuene

Lelu kituandala ku kalakala a tubungui kutanga

Ngó diondo messene/kizua nguikalakala ngui futa iosso uandala.

José Weza (2007, p. 51) presents us with some verses of the song translated into Portuguese. According to him, the song's lyrics declare: "master, come teach us to read and write. Since we were born, no one has ever taught us to read and write, and now that we need to work, you force us to know how to read and write. To which the master replies: sit down, let's start". From the researcher's perspective, the message printed in the lyrics directed the people to be attentive and the teachers to begin teaching, because it was necessary for the people to know how to read and write, and that better days would come.

As time went by, as could not be otherwise, the group began to be viewed with 'suspicion' by the colonial authorities, above all, because some of its members were politically involved with the MIA (Movement for the Independence of Angola) and, also, with pamphleteering work in the Bairro Operário, a neighborhood where part of the anti-colonial movement in Luanda was concentrated before the start of the war in 1961. Jacques A. dos Santos states that the first pamphleteer group was formed by Carlos Alberto Van-Dúnem, Liceu Vieira Dias, Amadeu Amorim, Agostinho Mendes de Carvalho (Uanhenga Xitu), among others. In 1957, the first printed pamphlets appeared in the Bairro Operário. In an interview with Rosalina Mateta (2010), Amadeu Amorim recalls:

"We felt pride and satisfaction when, after the distribution, we heard Angolans speaking in Kimbundu that the pamphlets were on the street [...]. The elements of the 'BO' mobilized people from different neighborhoods and even young white people from the Baixa who also distributed the pamphlets."

After these events, the group "N'gola Ritmos" started to be viewed with suspicion by the colonial authorities. The first step was to separate the ensemble components: Fontinhas was transferred to Moxico in 1957; Zé Maria was moved away to Lubango and, shortly after, Amadeu Amorim and Liceu Vieira Dias were arrested by the PIDE. The reason for the arrests, according to Amorim, was because they discovered that both were involved beyond the song: "we were politically involved in a working group, in a movement, the MIA". Liceu Vieira Dias's arrest occurred in 1959 under the charge of "subversive activities against national security," and in 1961 he was deported to the "Tarrafal" prison in Cape Verde. The report, available in the archives of the Portuguese political police, PIDE, and dated October 6, 1959, reports:

"On 10/2/1959, at the house of the mestizo MACHADO, driver for Lusolanda, a meeting was held, of which the components of the group KIMBANDAS DO RITMO took part. Subjects concerning the independence of Angola were discussed [...] It was also said that days ago they sent someone to ask LICEU VIEIRA DIAS and AMADEU AMORIM if they still belonged to the independence party or if they had given up, and they sent word back that they wouldn't give up until they saw Angola in Freedom [...] Luanda, October 6, 1959. FRANCISCO."

The same informant, in April 1960, would again inform PIDE about meetings of groups "with subversive and political ideas" connected to "N'gola Ritmos". In the PIDE documentation, several other pieces of information can be found about the possible relations between the musical group and the liberation struggle, as we can observe in this dossier: "In 1958 he was part of the Angolan artistic group N'GOLA, having been its president in 1959. Some rehearsals of this ensemble were substituted by meetings of the movement for the Independence of Angola", as recalled by one of the members of the Experimental Theater Group, GEXTO:

"[...] We used 'N'gola Ritmos', of which I feel I am an integral part, for several clandestine tasks, even though people did not know at the time that the struggle was clandestine and, therefore, thought that 'N'gola Ritmos' was just a musical ensemble with Angolan characteristics. But 'N'gola Ritmos' at that time did significant clandestine work. We once organized a picnic in Funda, because we needed to provide clarification of a political nature, so we organized a picnic where 90% of the people.... no! None of the people knew the reason for this picnic. However, it was through 'N'gola Ritmos', through its music, that we managed to mobilize, I can well say, almost 90% of the Village of Funda for the clarification [...]. One time, there was a simulated party at my house, where 'N'gola Ritmo' went to liven things up just to provide cover because this party was nothing more than a meeting with the Cuban Francisco Javier Hernandez, who was the first internationalist Cuban we met in Angola."

With the arrest of Liceu Vieira Dias and Amadeu Amorim and the transfer of Fontinhas to Moxico, in 1957, "N'gola Ritmos" would enter another phase, which occurs from the 1960s onwards. The present article, however, sought to present the group's trajectory during the fifties of the twentieth century, presenting and pointing out important characteristics of the ensemble, especially the concern of its members to disseminate the culture of their ancestors, in a period where the traditional songs, languages, and cultures of Angola were rejected by the colonial system and marked with the 'seal of inferiority'.

We sincerely hope that this text has contributed to alleviating, at least a little, the feeling of profound lack of knowledge we still have regarding not only the group "N'gola Ritmos," but rather the entire history of urban music in Angola.

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See Portuguese Version

Discography

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